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Climate and Nature – Living Soils Deliver for Both Parliamentary Event Report

Parliamentarians and leading experts gathered for a Roundtable discussion in Westminster to explore how soil-centric approaches can help to deliver the aims of the Climate and Nature (CAN) Bill. Keynote speeches at the event from diverse stakeholders highlighted how living soils act as a foundation for both climate action and nature recovery, and how soil-centric policy could unlock cross-policy benefits.

The event chair, Dr Merlin Sheldrake of the Fungi Foundation noted, *"Healthy soils are ancient life support systems… our dependence on healthy soils is total."*

The event report brings together the speeches and reflections of the participants, a diverse group of stakeholders representing soil's critical role across science, land management, public health, construction, water, education, and policy, including:

- Cross-party parliamentarians and policy makers
- Soil scientists and environmental researchers
- Farmers and regenerative agriculture practitioners
- Representatives from the construction and housing sectors
- Water industry leaders
- Public health experts
- Educators, filmmakers, and curriculum advocates
- NGOs and civil society organisations working on climate, nature, and land use

As Dr Roz Savage MBE MP writes in her Preface to the final report, the event united, *"…farmers, scientists, builders, educators and communities who understand that soil is not just a resource, but a living system."*

Across keynote presentations and cross-sector reflections, participants explored:

- The scientific evidence linking soil health to public health, immunity, and wellbeing
- The role of soils in construction, infrastructure, and flood mitigation
- Soil's centrality to biodiversity, water quality, and carbon storage
- The economic case for soil-centric approaches, including circular economy opportunities
- The need for education, skills, and soil literacy across society
- How soil-first policy can support resilient food systems and national security

Tony Juniper, Chair of Natural England, commented that *"This report underlines the growing body of evidence that soil is at the heart of the country's critical infrastructure, underpinning our wildlife, water regulation and food security while mitigating the impacts of a changing climate. The many pressures on soil health mean that we need to collaborate across sectors, including farming, construction, water, Nature restoration, spatial planning and public health to set our soils – and Nature more widely – on the path to recovery."*

Read or Download the Full Report

The full Climate and Nature – Living Soils Deliver for Both Report is now available. It includes keynote presentations, cross-sector reflections, policy analysis, and detailed recommendations for government, industry, and civil society. To download, share, or read the report, click on the item on the sidebar.

10 Key Takeaways from the Report (to create as a separate sidebar item / PDF download)

The following are the ten key takeaways from the final report of the Climate and Nature – Living Soils Deliver for Both Roundtable event, held in Westminster on 8 September 2025, which explored how soil-centric approaches can help to deliver the aims of the Climate and Nature (CAN) Bill. As stated by Ellen Fay from the Sustainable Soils Alliance in her keynote presentation: "…soil health impacts and links water quality, food security and public health, nature recovery, flood mitigation, construction - and even aspects of the circular economy."

1. Soil health is a public health issue - not just an environmental one

Finnish researchers Dr Aki Sinkkonen and Dr Marja Roslund presented compelling evidence that exposure to healthy, microbially rich soils improves immune regulation, reduces inflammation, and lowers the risk of asthma, diabetes and mental health conditions. They noted, *"Scientific evidence on the benefits of healthy soils is overwhelming."*, with their findings positioning soil health as a preventative public health measure with population-wide benefits.

2. Healthy soils can save the NHS billions

The same research estimated that expanding access to soil-supported environments could reduce medication use and chronic disease burden, generating potential NHS savings of up to £19 billion per year**.** Soil-centric urban greening, nature-based interventions and improved access to biodiverse outdoor spaces therefore represent major opportunities for health system resilience.

3. Construction practices must shift from soil disposal to soil reuse

Industry voices, including Ian Sandiford from Persimmon Homes and soil scientist and consultant Tim O'Hare from Tim O'Hare Associates, highlighted that the UK produces 18 million tonnes of surplus topsoil annually, most of which is treated as waste. Understanding soils in situ and reusing them locally - rather than sending them to landfill - can cut carbon, reduce vehicle movements, improve degraded soils elsewhere, and support a circular economy. Soil Resource Surveys and Soil Management Plans for construction works were cited as proven tools for improving outcomes.

4. Soil is critical infrastructure for climate resilience

Healthy soils absorb water, reduce flood risk, cool urban environments and support green infrastructure. As Sarah Dack of the UK Health Security Agency put it, *"You can't have green spaces if you don't have the soil."* Embedding soil health into planning, housing design and urban retrofit strengthens the UK's ability to withstand heatwaves, flooding and other climate impacts.

5. Soil underpins biodiversity and nature recovery

Participants, including Dr Elena Vanguelova from Forest Research, highlighted that soils host more than half of terrestrial species and store the majority of forest carbon. Soil ecosystems are essential for pollinators, woodland resilience and habitat creation. Without functioning soils, above-ground nature recovery efforts cannot succeed.

6. Farmers want to prioritise soil health - but policy must support them

Farmers and land managers described the structural, economic and temporal barriers that limit adoption of regenerative practices. They stressed the need for long-term, place-based, co-designed policies that build trust and enable soil stewardship. As several participants noted, farmers are willing and ready, but cannot shoulder the burden and act alone.

7. Soil literacy is a national skills gap

From nurseries to professional training, soil is largely absent from education. Claire Mackenzie, producer of *Six Inches of Soil*, highlighted how public understanding remains limited despite growing interest. While films and community initiatives help raise awareness, systemic change in curricula and professional development is needed to build a soil-literate society.

8. Soil-centric planning can transform development outcomes

Local authorities that require Soil Resource Surveys and Soil Management Plans report dramatically improved drainage, biodiversity, and public green space quality. Participants noted that soil-first planning reduces long-term maintenance costs, improves community wellbeing, and supports nature-based solutions.

9. Soil reuse and circular bioeconomy approaches offer major economic opportunities

Replacing synthetic fertilisers with circular alternatives, reusing construction soils, and reducing waste can strengthen food security, cut emissions and support a more resilient economy. This point was underscored by Chris Jones, Research and Development Manager at Northumbrian Water Group, who highlighted how healthy soils reduce water treatment costs and diffuse pollution, and improve catchment performance.

10. A 'soils first' approach can unify climate and nature policy

The Report concludes that soil-centric policy provides a coherent, evidence-based pathway to deliver climate goals, restore biodiversity, improve public health and support a circular economy. As the concluding section states, *"A nation that rebuilds its soils rebuilds its ecosystems, its resilience and itself."* Soil offers the common ground needed to integrate policy across departments, sectors and scales.